Declaration of Independence

In Congress, July 4, 1776 · Thomas Jefferson, principal author

Source: U.S. National Archives, archives.gov/founding-docs/declaration-transcript

Adopted by the Second Continental Congress on July 4, 1776, the Declaration announced the thirteen colonies' break from Great Britain. It draws on Enlightenment political philosophy — especially John Locke's natural-rights theory — to justify revolution. The document is organized in three movements: a philosophical preamble, a long list of grievances against King George III, and a formal declaration of independence.

Connect: Locke's natural-rights theory shaped Jefferson's language. What Locke phrases appear almost word-for-word in the Preamble?

Key Passages

Preamble (natural rights)

> We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.

Right of revolution

> That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness.

Sample grievances

> He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good… He has kept among us, in times of peace, Standing Armies without the Consent of our legislatures… For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent: For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury…

The declaration itself

> We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America … solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. Contextualization (DBQ/LEQ, 1 pt): Write one paragraph placing the Declaration in the broader Enlightenment / colonial-resistance context (1763–1776).

2. Identify TWO grievances and explain how each connects to a specific British policy after 1763.

3. How does Jefferson's phrase 'all men are created equal' square — or fail to square — with the practice of slavery in 1776?